CHHAAVA: REVIEW

Film that Launched a Thousand Protests

Action pyrotechnics and fire and brimstone dialogue that fan the fire of nationalism—*Chhaava* follows Bollywood's new template for historical extravaganzas

By **SUHANI SINGH**



For nearly two hours, *Chhaava* runs like a mishmash of the testosterone-heavy Marvel and DC universe action spectacles. Here, it leads to one battle after another, as Maratha king Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj (played by Vicky Kaushal) duels against a lion (cue Russell Crowe in *Gladiator*), excels in aerial fights and takes on the Mughal army, often single-handedly. Accompanied by a bombastic background score by A.R. Rahman, the historical extravaganza comes alive in the last half hour, when the punches are not literal, but verbal. With the protagonist captured and chained, audiences finally get to see the daring hero and his enemy, a haggard Aurangzeb (Akshaye Khanna), in one frame.

"*Mughalon ki taraf aa jaaao. Zindagi badal jaayegi. Bas tumhein apna dharm badalna hoga* (Join hands with the Mughals. Your life will change. All you have to do is convert to Islam)," says Khanna's Aurangzeb in a final offer of freedom to the brutalised Chhaava. The Maratha king, his spirit untethered, retorts, "*Humse haath mila lo... zindagi badal jaayegi aur dharm bhi badalna nahin padega* (Join hands with Marathas. Your life will change and you won't even have to change your faith)."

The 2-hour, 35 minute-long film directed by Laxman Utekar has set the box office ablaze, amassing Rs 541 crore in six weeks. The film's emphasis on Maratha pride and pluck has contributed to a performative rapture of sorts—clips show kids and women tearing up and chanting of slogans praising "Dharmarakshak Sambhaji Maharaj". If Kaushal's demanding physical act has won him a new fan base, Khanna as Aurangzeb is also a scene-stealer, using his hooded eyes to convey malevolence. Such is the enthusiasm that Parliament in New Delhi hosted a special screening of *Chhaava* for MPs on March 27.

Unlike Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Padmaavat*, *Chhaava* kept the villain's screen time limited and mostly avoided controversy, barring Raj Thackeray and Maharashtra minister Uday Samant taking offence at the portrayal of Sambhaji participating in a lejim dance. Utekar removed the sequence promptly. Some question the cinematic liberties taken. "Religion was not the only reason behind Sambhaji's death. Conversion was not Aurangzeb's focus," wrote Vishwas Patil, author of *Sambhaji, The Whirlwind* on indiatoday.in. "His interest was in gaining political control."

With Shivaji Sawant's book *Chhaava* as inspiration, the focus was to highlight the "warrior dimension" of Sambhaji, says Kaustubh Savarkar, one of the five script writers. Savarkar attributed *Chhaava*'s appeal to the "emotional connect" audiences felt watching "a Hindu raja" espouse the cause of swaraj. While Bhansali and Ashutosh Gowariker centred their historical epics on romance, recent fare has prioritised well-choreo-

CHHAAVA'S EMPHASIS ON MARATHA PRIDE HAS TRIGGERED PERFORMATIVE RAPTURE IN CINEMAS—CHANTS, CHEERS AND TEARS